

Simple File Backup Strategies

TECHNICAL MANUAL

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The sources gathered while writing this guide say the same thing in different ways: preparation beats repair. Below is what they actually returned.

****What each step looks like in practice****

- **Step 1**: Write a clear sentence that describes your end goal. This isn't about how you feel -- it's just a fact. For example, "By day's end, I will have backed up my entire C: drive to D:\backup\2023".
- **Gather everything**: List all files and folders you plan to copy. Double-check you've got the complete set.
- **Safe copy**: Before touching anything else, make a full backup of your original data. Store it in a safe location -- not on the same drive or connected by a live USB. Verify it opens correctly.
- **Step 4**: Perform your main task -- copying files -- using simple commands and defaults. Avoid custom settings that might complicate things. For example, use Windows Explorer's 'Send to > External Device' option for an easy backup.
- **Check result**: Open the backed-up data and compare it directly against your sentence from step 1. Ensure every file is there in its correct place. If not, you're missing something -- go back to your safe copy.
- **Document actions**: Write down exactly what steps you took. This document acts as your undo guide if things don't work out.

****Common mistakes****

- Skipping the safe copy because it seems redundant.
- Relying on tool prompts ("backup complete") instead of actually checking files.
- Changing too much at once, making it hard to identify where something went wrong.
- Thinking "no error" means everything's good -- errors can be silent in some cases.
- Not checking the result at all.

****How to check your work****

Always compare your end results against step 1. If anything is missing or seems out of place, go back to your safe copy and repeat the process. This isn't failure; it's just how you ensure everything stays intact.